The trouble was that despite all the changes occurring in South Asia, London was still viewing the world with Great Game vision, and formulating policy based on a time when a perceived affront to the empire's prestige could be met with implacable hostility. While the Home government remained worried about imperial appearances, however, the Indian government appeared altogether more practical. In the opinion of Delhi, Britain could no longer afford to be so uncompromising as London advocated. Instead, British officials needed to swallow their pride and accept the little offences caused by the Persians and Afghans, for the sake of attaining stable relations with those two nations. By 1921, Britain could no longer rely on the threat of its military prowess to gain what it wanted in South Asia. London appeared to forget that Britain had won (and lost) its control over Afghanistan's foreign affairs following a military campaign. That it expected the Afghan government to relinquish its independence in external relations in 1921 without such a military threat was an unrealistic hope on the Home government's part. As Reading put it to Montagu, although there might be disappointment in the policies followed by the Indian government the 'pressure of facts seems inexorable'.[158]

Compounding the discomfort of those struggling to accept Britain's reduced standing was the constant reminder that, in contrast, Soviet Russia appeared to be going from strength to strength in South Asia. London's authority was receding in the face of Moscow's. The retreat from Enzeli in 1920, in the face of the Red naval invasion, demonstrated the apparent impotence of the British military compared to Soviet Russia; the creation of treaties between Moscow and Tehran and Kabul in 1921 heralded a decline in British imperial clout, when its own diplomatic efforts towards these two nations proved unsatisfactory. For, as much as the Foreign Office might have appeared nonchalant, it is hard to deny the political blow the Soviet–Persian Agreement represented to Britain, particularly when one compares the optimism of the Foreign Office in 1918–1919 regarding Persia, to its negativity in 1921.

Hence why, when it came to the Soviet–Afghan Treaty, London became almost obsessed with the need to use this as a test case to see how British persuasion fared against Russian proffers of friendship. It was Russian intrigue that, in the opinion of Whitehall, was ousting British influence